to support. One of the most important update processes in an identity system is account recovery, where a user can rediscover a lost account or update lost, expired, or forgotten authentication factors. Whenever the attributes, password, or other information changes, the data connected to the identifier is updated and then repropagated to ensure that all connected systems reflect the latest identity state.

Account recovery deserves special mention because it is often the weak link in the identity life cycle. Consider an authentication system that requires strong authentication mechanisms but allows email resets. If the authentication system for email isn't as strong as that for the most critical piece of the system, then overall authentication is only as strong as that for email.

3.3.5 Terminate

When an identity relationship is no longer valid, it must be revoked to prevent unauthorized access. This might happen because an employee leaves the company, a customer closes an account, or a device terminates a connection. Proper termination ensures that orphaned accounts and lingering permissions do not create security risks. The General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) requires that organizations allow people to request the deletion of all the information held about them in most cases. Even without that requirement, it's often a good idea to close unused accounts to avoid account hijacking due to stale authentication factors.

TIP

The terminate phase of the identity lifecycle is often overlooked, but it's where many security issues begin. If not deactivated, dormant accounts—particularly those of former employees, contractors, or vendors—can be exploited. Always ensure that identity systems support automated offboarding and regular cleaning of unused identities to prevent unauthorized access.